

VFX

Computer Graphics (CG) encompasses all there is to Visual Effects (VFX). CG is, in fact, the engine that drives this train. There are various sub-branches under CG—such as animation, 3D character animation, creation of inorganic 3D objects, and even mixing and compositing them all.

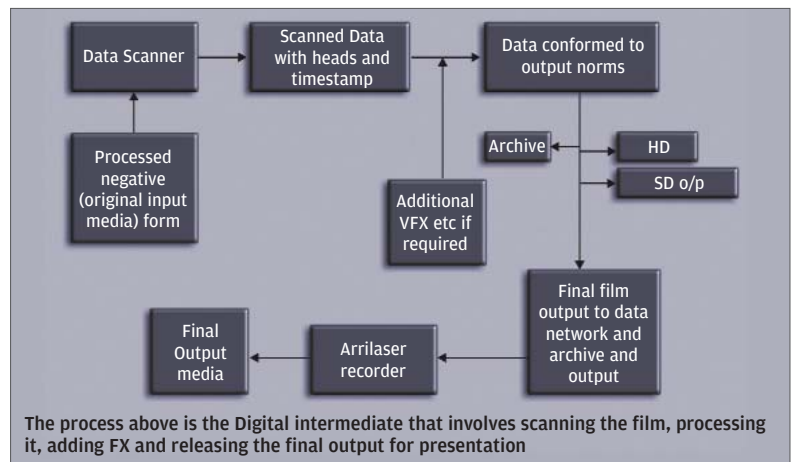
To explain these terms a little, 3D character animation would refer to movies such as *Shrek* and *Ice Age*, where the characters were entirely created using a computer, and lived out their lives right there! In the case of 3D inorganic objects, these are things such as hurricanes and smoke, and sometimes live action. Remember the twister in *Twister*?

In India, though, there is not much of a market for either. If anything, there is a small market for 3D inorganic objects. “The problem is that not too many filmmakers in India include this as part of their budget. They are still unable to quantify the results of using these technologies. By that, I mean they cannot translate it into monetary benefits,” says Khandpur.

Lokhandwala agrees to some extent, but is sure that India will catch up. In fact, India has already started using these technologies. “Creatively, the number of filmmakers employing and getting aware of digital tools is increasing. VFX has become an integral part of Indian filmmaking. It could be features, advertising commercials, music videos, documentaries. From subtle enhancements, to crucial corrections, to seamless compositions, to in-your-face computer generated imagery... we use them all,” he says.

Differentiating between the two basic types of VFX—the subtle and the in-your-face—reveals that the covert form is tougher to execute simply because no-one should notice it. “These are the subtle effects that need to be in a movie, but if they’re noticed and someone says, ‘Hey, that’s a nice effect’, it’s actually like telling us we didn’t do a good enough job of integrating it into the movie,” says Khandpur.

The other form, the obvious one, requires blasts, pyrotechnics, prosthetics, robotics and even miniatures. “These are the ones you don’t



want to hide! A blast has to be bigger, better and more realistic. This is where we are trying to create experts by working on a mentor-protégé system,” adds Khandpur.

Some of the other forms of effects that are commonly done include wire stamping. This just involves cleaning out the wires by which actors hang during stunts. “Not just us, but most people involved in this work hate wire stamping. But we can’t help it. If only the director involved us earlier, I think we could do something about it,” laments Khandpur.

An example of this much-hated stamping would be the climax scene of the recent Salman Khan-Fardeen Khan-Anil Kapoor starrer *No Entry*. When all three leading men are hanging on to dear life on what is shown as a cliff, in reality, they couldn’t be safer, standing on *terra firma* at Khandala. But the actual shot shows them on a cliff overlooking the sea. The sea, the cliff and the actors, too, were added using a computer. The entire scene (and the film) was then processed to maintain the same colour temperature, and composited to look like they were hanging over a cliff. The only thing that was real here was the hanging! To complete the entire sequence, the safety rope they were hanging by had to be stamped out later, as well as any traces of harnesses and hooks.

TV Commercial

